The Long-Term Care Financial Checklist

What to gather about Mom's income, accounts, insurance and care bills.

Mom's care bills have started arriving, and her paperwork has never been in one place. Before anyone tries to work out what it all comes to, make sure you have these in hand. Check what you've found. Anything unchecked is something still to look for, not a verdict about Mom or about your family.

Gather

- [ ] Something in writing for each source of monthly income: Social Security, a pension, an annuity, anything else that arrives regularly. [1]
- [ ] A recent statement for every account you know of: checking, savings, CDs and money market accounts, and any investment, brokerage or retirement accounts. [1]
- [ ] Insurance policies and contracts: life insurance, annuities and any long-term care insurance. [1]
- [ ] Deeds, titles and registrations for real estate, vehicles and other significant property. [2]
- [ ] The latest bill or rate sheet from the facility or care provider.
- [ ] Recent tax returns, if you can find them. [2]

Write down

- [ ] Whose name is on each account, policy and property, exactly as the paperwork shows it, including anything owned jointly. Where you can't tell, write “not sure.”
- [ ] What Mom's care costs each month, copied from the bill, and her other regular monthly expenses.
- [ ] What she owes: a mortgage, loans, credit cards, and who each is owed to. [1]
- [ ] Any unusual withdrawals, gifts or transfers you come across, with the date and the amount shown. Write them down as you found them, without deciding what they mean.

Ask

- [ ] Mom, if she's able, and your brothers and sisters: which accounts, policies or papers they know of that you haven't found.
- [ ] The facility's business office or the care provider: what the monthly charge includes, and what is billed separately.
- [ ] The bank, the pension office or the insurance company: anything about a statement or a policy that you can't tell from the paper.
- [ ] Your Medicaid planner: which of these records they would want to see, and how far back.

What this checklist doesn't do

It helps you gather and notice. It doesn't add anything up, say what any account or policy means for paying for Mom's care, or tell you what to do with it. Rules vary by state, and nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice. Those questions go to your Medicaid planner or the appropriate licensed professional, and to the next step below.

Ready for the next step?

You've gathered what you could, and you can see what hasn't turned up yet. The planning interview takes it from there: it asks about your family's situation, one question at a time, and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for Mom's care.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Items marked 1 or 2 follow the lists of financial records that the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau and AARP suggest keeping together. The rest come from the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own working list for this step.

1. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Planning for diminished capacity and illness
2. AARP, 5 Steps to Organize Your Loved One's Financial Records

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